After Velu Thampi Dalawa's last remaining Nair troops had been defeated in battles near Nagercoil and Kollam he sought refuge in the Kali temple at Mannadi, inland from Quilon. As the Company's troops closed in he chose to die by his own hand rather than surrender. On the orders of Raja Balarama Varma of Travancore – who, no doubt, took his orders from Colonel Macaulay – Velu Thampi's body was taken to Trivandrum and hanged from a gibbet outside the city, an act condemned by Governor-General Lord Minto as 'repugnant to humanity and the principles of civilised governance'. Macaulay was censured and dismissed, but kept his pension. So ended what can quite justifiably be described as the first real Indian revolt against British rule in India, and on that ground alone Velu Thampi Dalawa deserves his honoured place in history.

The death of Raja Balarama Varma in 1810 without a male heir led to a struggle for succession which ended with his niece ascending the royal *gadi*: twenty-year-old Rani Gowri Lakshmi Bayi. Macaulay's successor as British Resident, Colonel John Munro, lost no time in supporting her claim to the throne, and very quickly positioned himself to become the queen's staunchest ally – as well as becoming perhaps a little too friendly with her younger sister. It says a lot for the young queen's character that when the Nambudiri Brahmins objected to Munro setting up an inoculation programme to combat the smallpox then raging in many parts of Travancore, she and her family were among the first to be vaccinated, and made sure that this was widely known.

Like his predecessor before him, Munro very quickly concluded that Travancore's government machinery was rotten from top to bottom, writing to his masters in Madras that 'No description can produce an adequate impression of the tyranny, corruption and abuses of the system, full of activity and energy in everything mischievous, oppressive and infamous, but slow and dilatory to effect any purpose of